

Imperial Japan

The story of Japan's Imperial Age is filled with feuding clans and warlike samurai, constantly battling for wealth and power. But it was also a place where art and culture flourished, and where honour was respected above all.

RULE OF THE SHOGUNS

Although the ruler of Japan was the emperor, the country was really governed by the shogun. He was the most powerful of a group of wealthy, influential military generals called daimyo.



THE FULL TITLE SEI TAISHOGUN MEANS "GREAT GENERAL SUBDUING THE BARBARIANS"

FEARSOME WARRIORS

Japan's history was shaped by the military men who battled on behalf of warring clans.

- **MINAMOTO YORITOMO (1147–99)**
After fierce struggles with rival clans and his own family, he finally became shogun in 1192. At his death seven years later, his son took over as ruler.
- **SASAKI TAKATSUNA (1160–1214)**
Commander in the war between the Minamoto and Taira clans, he saved Yoritomo's life at the Battle of Ishibashiyama.
- **NITTA YOSHISADA (1301–38)**
Resistance leader and general. At his final battle, he was surrounded by his enemies and, rather than be captured, he cut off his own head.
- **TOKUGAWA IEYASU (1542–1616)**
After civil war, Tokugawa Ieyasu united Japan under his control. His descendants ruled for the next 260 years.
- **KATO KIYOMASA (1561–1611)**
A formidable military leader and devout Buddhist, he led a brutal campaign to rid Japan of Christianity.



SASAKI TAKATSUNA



KATO KIYOMASA



NITTA YOSHISADA

MAGNIFICENT CASTLES

In the 16th century, noble families, who were often at war with their neighbours, built mighty fortresses to protect their land and armies. These magnificent castles also served as symbols of the clans' power and wealth.



HIMEJI CASTLE

Also called the Castle of the White Heron, because its delicate, curved roofs resemble birds' wings.

FAITH AND WORSHIP

Most people followed a faith called Shinto – "the way of the gods" – a belief that all living things possess a divine spirit called *kami*. Worshipers held rituals and left offerings to the *kami* at specially built shrines all over Japan.



SHRINE ENTRANCE AT MIYAJIMA, SOUTHERN JAPAN
The gateway to a Shinto shrine is called a *torii*.

SAMURAI WARRIORS

Samurai were men of noble birth who were trained in all aspects of fighting and war. They were the only people allowed to carry a *katana* and a *wakizashi* (a pair of swords known collectively as *daisho*) in public.

The *Kabuto* (helmet) often featured a decorative crest

The *Mempo* was an iron mask used for protection and to scare enemies

Cheek and neck protector

Light armour, made from metal scales, allowed for easy movement



SAMURAI SUIT OF ARMOUR, 19TH CENTURY